In 1971, India's shift away from non-alignment accelerated as relations with the United States reached a nadir. A sudden American *rapprochement* with China and the prospect of a third war with Pakistan in response to a military crackdown in East Pakistan prompted India to enter a 20-year treaty of peace, friendship, and cooperation with the Soviet Union. In immediate terms, the treaty allowed India to intervene in East Pakistan by providing security against Chinese intervention and a shield from international censure in the United Nations Security Council.[19] More broadly, the treaty signalled a decisive move away from the West. US support for Pakistan in the 1971 war, though limited, drove the wedge between India and the United States deeper, and following the Indian victory in East Pakistan, American influence waned on the subcontinent. Though not an explicit military alliance, the Indo–Soviet treaty was a sharp departure from non-alignment. It stated that neither country would enter into a military alliance or hostile actions against the other. If either side were subjected to an attack or threat, the two countries agreed to "enter into mutual consultations in order to remove such a threat and to take appropriate effective measures to ensure peace and security of their countries," hinting that the treaty allowed room for a military alliance in any circumstances that constituted a threat to peace.[20] Equivocal language allowed India to maintain a semblance of non-alignment, but the treaty in effect created deterrence against any form of collusive threat from the US–China–Pakistan combine and rendered India increasingly dependent on the Soviet Union for its defence capabilities.

India used the move toward the Soviet Union to secure its place as a regional power-broker. The treaty paved the way for India to engage Pakistan militarily, divide that country, and create Bangladesh in 1971. Soviet deterrence, paired with its veto of resolutions in the Security Council aimed at